

JUXTAPOSITION

Placing two opposite ideas right next to each other



1 What is it?

Juxtaposition (juks-tuh-poh-ZISH-un)

Juxtaposition places two **strongly contrasting** ideas or images directly next to each other, in the same sentence or moment, to create a jolt of surprise or meaning.

idea A + idea B (side by side, same moment)

2 See it in action

War writing

Soldiers laughed and joked just metres from the bodies of the fallen.

Irony

The sign read "Peaceful Protest" above a wall of riot shields.

Tone shift

She wore a wedding dress stained with mud.

Character

A gentle giant — enormous hands, but a voice soft as a lullaby.



Good spot!

The key test: are the two opposite ideas touching in the **same moment**? If yes, that closeness is exactly what makes it juxtaposition.

FUN FACT

Oxymorons (like "deafening silence") are actually a tiny, word-level form of juxtaposition — the same "opposites touching" trick, just squeezed into two words instead of two images.

3 Why writers use it

Juxtaposition helps writers: create shock, highlight irony, expose a contradiction, or make the reader stop and really think about how two things can exist together at once.

It's a favourite in war poetry and social commentary, because putting something beautiful next to something horrifying (or vice versa) forces the reader to feel the wrongness of it.

4 Don't mix it up!

Juxtaposition

- **Same moment**, right next to each other
- Creates **shock** or irony
- "Roses growing through rubble"

Contrast

- Can be spread across a **whole text**
- Highlights a **difference** or theme
- "A poor village vs a rich city"



Watch out!

Juxtaposition is specifically about the **shock of nearness** — two opposites touching. If the opposite ideas are far apart in the text, that's better described as contrast instead.



Keep going!

Juxtaposition almost always creates a **feeling of wrongness or irony** — naming that emotional effect is exactly what examiners look for.

5 Quick recap

Two opposites, side by side

Same sentence/moment

Creates shock or irony



Mfalme says...

Try writing one image that juxtaposes beauty and horror, like "a butterfly landed on the broken glass" — small phrase, big impact.